The catalyst for change was an average of 28, across two Ashes series. These are the definitive examinations of temperament and technique. I was averaging between 45 and 50 against other nations but falling short against the best team in the world, in the most exposed environment the international game offers.

I rejigged things, revising my technique entirely so that I could hit the ball straighter. It was initially successful, since I had an immediate run of three Test centuries, but I eventually became too rigid. My game had self-imposed restrictions, and it set me up to fail. Goochy's principles were sound: they had to be reasserted.

Batting is a manifestation of the mind. There were times, on the Ashes tour of 2010–11 and in India in 2012, when I wasn't exactly in the zone, that Zen-like state snooker players speak of, when everything slows down and doubts are dispelled, but I just found the rhythm. I wasn't seeing the ball better or quicker, but I had a sense of flow. When I got to the crease it just happened for me, without the battle.

A particular session in Adelaide before the second Test in December 2010 is imprinted on my memory. It was one of those occasions when Flower consciously put us under pressure in the nets. This was the antithesis of cosy, confidence-building training. He told the coaches to discomfort us by flinging the ball aggressively, trying to find the edge or shatter the stumps. If you got in the way of one, tough. It was a reassertion of the old principle of training hard to play easy.

Goochy was hurling the ball down with the dog-stick, the pet training aid which had come into fashion as a perverse aid to practice around 2007. It was a flat wicket, so it wasn't too tough in terms of an examination of technique, but he was trying to knock my head off, or hurry me into a mistake. Confrontation makes the adrenaline flow.

I left anything that wasn't hitting the stumps. I was driving, cutting, clipping, pulling anything that was slightly wide or short. I was surprised by the intensity of the feeling of being at ease. I wasn't forcing myself to score the runs or find the shot. If it wasn't there to drive, it remained undriven. Everything just happened. After forty minutes or so, when I was error free, Goochy came down to me and said, 'You're in good nick. Make it count.'

Some golfers become almost mystical when they talk about that unconscious excellence. I never allow myself to ignore the danger of getting out, but that effortlessness is seductive to any professional